Enabling International Residents to Participate in Local Government Decisions

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Executive Summary

This report investigates how technology could help international residents in Melbourne better understand and participate in local government decisions and community activities. These barriers may include language difficulties, limited time, low perceived relevance, and difficulty finding or understanding reliable information.

The investigation aimed to understand how immigrants and international students currently receive information about local government, what motivates or discourages their participation, and what difficulties they experience when accessing government information and services. We conducted an ethnographic study using observations and semi-structured interviews. Our observations covered a City of Melbourne council meeting, a community book club, a public information display, and the City of Melbourne website. We also interviewed eight international residents, including three international students and five immigrants.

Our findings identified five recurring themes: language, time, personal relevance, interaction with authorities, and accessibility of information. Participants were more likely to pay attention to policies or activities that affected their everyday lives or matched their interests. However, language difficulties and unclear or difficult-to-find information could discourage residents from understanding or participating in local government activities. Our observations also showed that community events and informal information sharing can help residents communicate, build connections, and access information. These findings suggest that the challenge is not simply a lack of interest in local government, but also whether residents can easily discover, understand, and access information that is relevant to them.

Based on these findings, the technology developed in the next stage should provide multilingual and clearly presented information, make relevant local government information easy to discover in everyday environments, organize information into understandable categories, and provide interactive question-and-answer support. It should also protect users' privacy and provide accurate, up-to-date information with clear sources. Together, these requirements aim to reduce information and language barriers and make local government information more accessible to international residents.

Introduction and background

People living in Melbourne can participate in local government decision-making through public consultations, surveys, community activities, and council meetings. These decisions may affect residents' daily lives, including public transport, parks, housing, community services, and neighborhood development. However, not everyone is aware of these opportunities, understands how the consultation process works or feels motivated to participate. Some people may only pay attention when a decision has an obvious and direct effect on their personal lives.

This investigation focuses on immigrants and international students living in Melbourne. People who are new to Australia may not be familiar with the responsibilities of local councils or the ways in which residents can express their opinions. Language difficulties, unfamiliar government processes, limited local connections and uncertainty about where to find reliable information may further reduce their opportunities to participate. International students may face additional challenges because their everyday lives are often centered around their university, employment and immediate social networks rather than the local community in which they live.

Previous Australian research suggests that community engagement is closely connected to international students' everyday experiences and wellbeing. Based on a survey of 1,372 international students and focus group interviews with 16 students, Soong and Mu (2026) found that English proficiency and local friendships contributed to students' wellbeing. Their findings also show that language can influence how confidently and comfortably international students interact with members of the local community. These interactions occur in different physical and virtual settings, including university campuses, libraries, public spaces, and social media platforms. This suggests that participation is influenced not only by whether information is available, but also by whether people feel welcomed, confident, and connected to the wider community.

This situation creates an opportunity to design digital technologies that make local government information easier to discover, understand, and respond to. A new tool or service could help users find decisions relevant to their location and daily lives, explain consultation processes in accessible language, and provide clearer ways to participate. However, an appropriate solution should be based on users' actual needs rather than assumptions about what technology they require.

Therefore, this investigation aims to understand how immigrants and international students currently learn about local government decisions, how willing they are to participate and what factors encourage or discourage their involvement. Through interviews and observations, the study seeks to identify the

information channels people use, the issues that motivate participation, and the support they need. These findings will then be used to develop user needs and design requirements for a technology-based concept that can support more accessible and inclusive participation.

Investigation methods

To understand the technology requirements and constraints, we conducted an ethnographic study using two data collection methods: observation and interviews.

Observation (The observation questions are listed in Appendix 1.1):

We conducted observations at three physical sites and one online site: a City of Melbourne council meeting (covert), a Chinese book club at The Dock library (overt), a public space displaying City of Melbourne posters (covert), and the City of Melbourne website.

At the council meeting (about 60 attendees), we were passive participants, observing them without getting involved in the discussion. At the book club (about 20 participants), we were active participants, which we informed the coordinator before attending the event, introduced our purpose at the event, and joined the activities. This showed us how the community support system works, how participants experience the event, and what their backgrounds and needs are. At the poster site, we acted as non-participants, observing ordinary passersby without interacting with anyone (DeWalt & DeWalt, 2011, pp. 23–25).

Observation suited our aim of understanding how the public engages with these activities in a natural setting (Baker, 2006, p. 172).

Interview (The questions are listed in Appendix 1.2):

We conduct semi-structured interviews with eight international residents. Three were current students at the University of Melbourne, and five were immigrants who had lived in Australia for a couple of years. Most were friends of the researchers or were introduced by mutual friends.

The interview questions varied with the identity of the interviewee and how well they understood local government and public policy. Because we wanted detailed answers rather than yes/no responses, we needed to ask follow-up questions about what interviewees said, and semi-structured interviews suited for this purpose (Adams, 2015, pp. 493–494).

Analysis

We used thematic analysis to identify common reasons and themes related to our research questions and observations. Because our data was qualitative rather than structured quantitative data, we followed the steps suggested by Braun and Clarke (2006). First, we familiarized ourselves with the data. We then generated initial codes and searched for themes across the observation and interview data. After collecting the themes, we reviewed them and then defined and named each theme with a clear, easy-to-identify name. Finally, we produced the report.

Researching ethical and limitations:

We used pseudonyms in this report and pixelated all photographs of people, and we did not take photographs where they were not allowed. Interviewees were informed that their responses would be recorded and that they could withdraw at any time. We did not inform the organizers of the council meeting or the public-space observations, because arranging permission for overt observation would have been difficult and all meetings would be published on the official website.

Our study has limitations that may prevent it from reflecting the full pictures. First, we could not access City of Melbourne staff because of local policies, so our findings do not include the official perspective. Second, because of the research team's own background, most interviewees came from Taiwan or China. Although we include some variation in nationality, this may still have introduced bias.

Findings

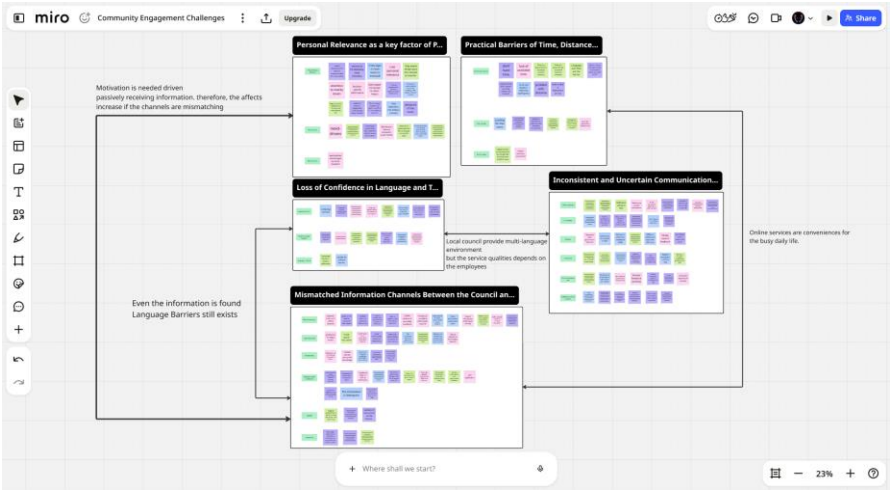
The key insights we found from the observations and interviews are as follows, you can see the note taken on the transcripts in Appendix 2 and 3.

Approximately 147 codes from all the interviews (Fig 1), and each team member analyzed the codes individually, you can see the captures of the progress in appendix 4.



(Fig. 1 Codes generated from investigation)

Then the codes are categorized into five themes with the relations between (Fig 2), for a larger picture, you can see in appendix 4.



(Fig 2: Themes and connections)

Theme 1: Loss of Confidence in Language and Terminology

Although the council provides multilingual services, difficulties in understanding specific terminology and speaking fluently still reduce residents' wilingness to participate (see Appendix 5.1).

At the Chinese book club, we observed participants communicate and exchange information in their preferred language. P6 mentioned "*The council mostly does provide multi-language material, so they do try to accommodate people of different language and cultural backgrounds.*" However, residents still find it difficult to express their opinion when technical terms are involved. P3 explained that "*at these events you might need to communicate using local terminology/language usage, and I'm not confident enough there to express my position well,*" while P8 said, "*If there are technical terms, I still need to look them up. They're not words foreigners like us normally use.*" This also applies online, as P1 pointed out "*The online process is useful, but it still has to be completed in English.*"

This suggests that translation alone is not enough. Although multilingual materials already exist, residents still struggle with policy terms. Our design should provide plain-language summaries of each policy and explain key terms, so residents can understand the issue before deciding whether to participate.

Theme 2: Practical Barriers of Time, Distance and Event Fees

Residents reduce their willingness to participate in council activities due to practical costs such as time, travel distance, and the cost of events (see Appendix 5.2).

Several participants described busy daily lives in which time and location affect their willingness to attend council meetings. P2 stated "*I do feel like time of the day and where the location is will be the biggest factor,*" and P3 said, "*I'm a full-time student, so I don't have free time to attend these events.*" P5 also shared "*I would maybe visit one of the meetings but definitely not regularly.*" Cost was also a concern; P4 considers "*whether or not it's free as well. And, um, sometimes if it needs you to buy a ticket or register to go.*"

Since event fees are set by councils and organizers, they are outside the scope of our design. Instead, we focus on time and location by allowing residents to read event summaries and submit feedback online at any time, without attending in person.

Theme 3: Personal Relevance as a key factor of Participation

Residents' willingness to participate depends on whether the topic affects their daily life or if they have requirements for the local policies (see Appendix 5.3).

At Future Melbourne Committee, most attendees left once the topic they cared about had been discussed. The majority of interviewee shared this view. P7 would participate “if the activity concerned a topic that interested me or was directly relevant to me,” P1 state “If an issue had a significant and direct effect on me, I would probably participate.” and P2 said “I feel like it's affecting me in my personal life. Yeah, I would like to know more about it.” .

Our design should therefore let residents choose their local area and topics of interest, such as parks, housing or student life and briefly explain how each policy may affect residents' daily lives.

Theme 4: Inconsistent and Uncertain Communication with the Council

Residents' experiences of communicating with the council vary by council area, staff member and channel. In addition, their unfamiliarity with the council's structure makes it difficult to find the right department to raise their concerns. This inconsistency and uncertainty can reduce residents' willingness to participate in local governance (see Appendix 5.4).

P3 felt a high sense of "emotional value" because letters clearly explained what support was available, whereas P4 found council "very friendly" but Monash "a lot stricter and sort of cold," adding,” I'd probably not want to go to it as much.” P1 also notice “I have encountered differences between staff members, possibly because each staff member has a different level of familiarity with particular rules or clauses.” Beyond inconsistency, residents were uncertain about how to raise concerns. When a local park changed it rules, P4 said, "I didn't know who to talk to or what the approach. I felt like anything I did wouldn't change what happened." P6 described the council’s attitude to minor issues "if it's not really a big deal, and I can't do anything about it, you'll just have to wait" “

To reduce uncertainty, our design should clearly show which council and department are responsible for each policy or event and how to contact them. Residents should also be able to track the status of their feedback, so they know it has been received.

Theme 5: Mismatched Information Channels Between the Council and Residents

Although the council mainly distributes information through physical mail and flyers, international residents more often rely on social media and friends to stay informed. As a result, they find it difficult to receive or locate council information, which in turn reduces their willingness to participate in local governance (see Appendix 5.5).

For long-term residents, physical mail remains effective. P1 state " physical mail has remained the main channel for this kind of public-policy information, and P2 preferred "a flyer in my mailbox." However, international students described a different pattern. P7 had "not received this kind of information through physical mail" and "did not know what events were taking place in Melbourne." Instead, P5 noted that "the only kind of info I get about stuff going on in Melbourne … is what I see on Instagram," and P8 found visa information "On Instagram, in Reels or posts." P7 also mention "I did not know what events were taking place in Melbourne." At the Chinese Book Club, most attendees were also unaware that the event offered much more than books.

Rather than replacing physical mail, our design should complement it by delivering council information through channels that newer residents already use, such as email or app notifications and shareable social media content, as P6 suggested "an email subscription, or a monthly newsletter."

Personas & scenarios

User characteristics:

We discussed two characteristics amount two main groups during our investigation. The international student and the immigrates. Since gender is not a big concern during the investigation, the gender in persona is in an easy–to–read manner.

Jason Lee (Immigrant Representative):

“I know they want to help, but I don't always know who to ask, or how to say it right.”

Background:

- Early 30s, has been living in Australia for 5-10 years.
- Living outside the CBD, has a stable job and a stable relationship with his partner.
- English is not his first language.
- He is not a politically active person, looking for a normal, stable life in Australia.
- He is not very familiar with how different local government departments are structured.
- Occasionally speaking with the neighborhood to get updates, but usually not a community speaker.
- Mostly receive information from mailing or notices in public spaces.

Lifestyle:

- He is enthusiastic about certain topics, such as pets or sports, and pays attention to related events.
- Frequently having a short walk around the community, either to get familiar with the neighborhood or to do grocery shopping.

Goal:

- To find ways to voice his opinions to the local council.
- To know which department, person to ask when he has an issue. So that he doesn't need to guess which department or who he has to speak to.
- He wishes to be understood and taken seriously when he reports about some kind of issue happening in the community.

Frustration:

- Struggles to express his concerns precisely in English, and understanding the "correct" terminology to use to be taken seriously
- Unsure which department to contact, or what terminology to use to be taken seriously without misunderstanding.
- He has had positive experiences with clear, helpful staff, but also poor experiences with certain offices.
- The local council holds in-person meetings, but he often can't attend due to time constraints; even when he does, he finds it hard to express his opinion because he isn't sure who to address, which department is responsible, or what terminology to use.
- Even when he eventually gets the chance to report an issue, it usually doesn't get addressed immediately, he feels that his opinion isn't taken seriously

Scenario:

Jason recently received an announcement from the local council regarding new policies for the nearby park. He felt unsatisfied with the changes, and he also found some neighbors who had similar feelings. He then began searching for approaches that can express his opinions; however, he found that he didn't know which department he could speak to. He then when to the local council office for in-person consultation, but he felt it was difficult to explain his concerns even though the office found someone who could speak in his language, the attitude and the knowledges of the employee gave him a terrible experience. He gave up expressing his idea eventually and tried to form up the suggestion to the general suggestion email, but it took several working days for the offices to proceed, and he couldn't get to know if the council would take his words seriously. In the end, he just got used to the change and accepted the new policies.

Kate Yang (International Student Representative)

"I am not sure whether I fully understand all policies from governments"

Background:

- She is not originally from Australia
- She is primarily here for studying master's degree
- She has stayed in Melbourne for over half of a year but less than a year
- Her daily life center around university, part-time job or other leisure activities

Lifestyle:

- She gets information mainly through social media, or self-search. Friends around her generally do not discuss policy topics, though it's varied by individuals.
- She usually focusses on the policy that will affect her or is relevant to her.
- She notices some posters on the streets but does not treat them as primary.
- She considers language as the main barrier for her to understand the content of policy.

Goal:

- She wants the channel of delivering information from the government to be improved, such as being more accessible, clearer, and more integrated.
- Being assisted by someone who can speak her first language will be very helpful for her to understand the policy.

Frustration:

- Website lack clarity.
- There are delays in updates about service disruptions, such as tram delays.
- Without citizenship, her motivation to engage with events is lower, even though she is interested in them.
- No channel brings the information relevant to her proactively, which she might miss any information that she hasn't searched for.

Scenario:

Since Kate arrived in Melbourne, she has occasionally searched the City of Melbourne website for information relevant to her; however, the website was not clear enough for Kate to find what she was looking for. Also, the content on the website is in English, which made her feel unsure when trying to

interpret it, since English is not her first language. For instance, there was one time Kate found that the tram she was going to take was delayed, but without any announcement at the stop or online. After spending some time searching for a clear answer, she gave up checking and decided to just wait, feeling that these platforms were not really designed with someone like her in mind.

Design requirements

Based on the observations and interviews we conducted, the main design idea is to improve the accessibility and discoverability of local public policy information and also offer the function where residents who face language barriers have easier experience.

Functional requirements:

Requirement 1: Multilingual information

The technology should provide the options to have multiple languages to reduce the language-related barriers.

Requirement 2: Personalization and engagement

Technology should suggest information according to the user's interests or their status (e.g., student or resident). Provide a picture of the relations between official information and the user.

Requirement 3: Great visibility

The technology should be rather simple to discover or spotted for the public to use it without putting too much effort into it.

Requirement 4: QA support

The technology should allow users to ask questions and then give correct answers or explanations of local policies or activities.

Requirement 5: Feedbacking and trackable

The technology should provide pathway to give feedback or opinion for local council, and user should be able to track their issue reported.

Non-functional requirements:

Requirement 6: Privacy

The technology should clear the record and start a new one every time users are done with the experience.

Requirement 7: Accuracy / trustworthiness

Information should always be up-to-date and give a clear indication of where the information comes from.

Requirement 8: Simple and easy-to-use

All the features of the technology should be easy to understand and straight forward to use for the first-time user.

Conclusion and next steps

The conclusion we have now are the key findings which are the common themes: Language, Time, Relationship with the case, Attitude of the staff, Approaches of spreading the information. And in the design phase of our project, we aim to create a design concept that addresses the problem of approaches to spreading information and language.

The reason we would only focus on these two themes/problems is because we can't really control or change the other factors/themes we discover since it's very subjective (depends on the users), so we will only concentrate on the variable that we are able to change. If the project is successfully created as we designed, we think this would be a lot more helpful since it'll be seen on the street where the people in Melbourne can interact with it in everyday life, and with the function that there are multiple languages options, it'll also make the uses whose main language is not English a lot more easier to understand and comprehend to use the project.

Acknowledgements

AI tools were used during the preparation of this report to support brainstorming and writing development. AI was used to provide suggestions for the structure and wording of the Executive Summary, and to generate initial ideas for possible design requirements based on the findings of our investigation. The final content, interpretation of the fieldwork data, and design decisions were reviewed and edited by the group members to ensure that they accurately reflected our own research and findings.

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Appendix

Appendix 1.1: Observation Question

Observation Question - City of Melbourne council meeting (covert)

1. What is the meeting agenda?
2. How many people attended the meeting? Zoom ?
3. What are the characteristics of the participants?
4. Level of engagement of the participants?
5. Do participants keep conversations with others regarding the topic discussed during the meeting?
6. Is it easy to find the entrance to the meeting?
7. How do people participate online?
8. How are residents' participation records documented?

Observation Question - A public space displaying City of Melbourne posters (covert)

1. Is there any people notice the poster ?
2. What do they do when notice the poster?
3. Their characteristics: How old does He/She looks like? What race does he/she looks like?
4. What are they doing before notice the poster?
5. What time has the observation been taken?
6. Where is the observation been taken?
7. What is the weather during the observation?

Appendix 1.2: Interview Questions

Group 1: International Students

Part 1: Basic Information

1. What is your name?
2. What are you studying? / What's your major?
3. How long have you lived in Melbourne?
4. Where are you from?

Part2: Engagement with public policy

1. Would you consider yourself someone who is actively involved in, or keeps up with public policy? (It can be policy back home, or here is Australia)
2. What makes you feel motivated- or maybe unmotivated - to follow or get involved in public policy.
3. Since moving to Melbourne, has your habit of following local news or policies changed at all? (Do you follow it more or less now, and why?)
4. How do you usually stay updated on these issues? (For example, through news outlets, social media, or something else?)
5. Do your friends or classmates ever talk about local policies or news? Does their interest influence yours?

Part 3: Awareness of Official Melbourne Information

1. Have you come across any recent official events or updates released by the City of Melbourne?

   If YES:

   a. How did you hear about it? (Friends, noticeboards, news, social media, etc.)
   b. Did you happen to stumble upon it, or do you actively check for updates?
   c. Are there any other local issues or topics you've been following?

   If NO:

   a. What do you think is the main reason? (Is the information hard to find, or are you just not that interested?)

2. What kinds of topics or issues do you think you'd naturally care more about? (No worries if nothing comes to mind!)
3. When looking for local information, do you prefer getting it directly from official sources, or through reshared posts and second-hand sources?
4. When you see news reshared on social media, do you usually fact-check it with official sources? What makes a source feel trustworthy to you?
5. If the local government wants to reach people like you, which platform would be the most convenient? (e.g., Instagram, email, specific apps, or social groups?)
6. Do you feel like language barriers affect how involved you get?
7. Does not fully understanding the Australian administrative system affect your motivation to follow official news?
8. When you face challenges as a student—like housing, casual jobs, or visa issues—where do you usually turn for help or information? If you've ever reached out to official services or support here:
    a. How was that experience overall?
    b. Would you use those services again? (Feel free to share a bit more detail if you'd like!)

Group 2: Immigrants

Part 1: Background

1. What's your name?
2. Where are you from?
3. Could you briefly introduce yourself? (Job, Age, Interest, Native Language, …)
4. How long have you lived in Melbourne?
5. Which area do you live in?
6. How do you feel about Melbourne (Victoria)?
7. How do you usually get information related to your local area? (social media, neighbors, community noticeboards, etc.)
8. Did anyone (friends, social workers, migrant support organizations, etc.) help you understand local public affairs or community activities when you were settling in?
9. Are you aware of what decisions your local council is currently making — for example park redevelopments, transport planning, or any recent public consultation?

If YES → continue with Group A: Policy-Aware Immigrants

If NO → continue with Group B: Policy-Unaware Immigrants

Part 2: Policy-aware vs. Policy Unaware

Group A: Policy-Aware Immigrants

Theme A1: Awareness and information channels

A1. What specific decisions or consultations are you aware of? How did you find out about them?

A2. Have the channels you use to get this kind of information changed over time? (e.g. from relying on others at first, to now actively searching yourself)

Theme A2: Participation experience

A3. Have you ever actually attended a local government information session, public hearing, or online survey?

If Yes → How did you hear about it? How did you feel afterwards — did you feel your input mattered?

If No → despite being aware: What stopped you from actually taking part? (language, time, feeling it wasn't relevant, unsure how, etc.)

A4. Do you find these consultation formats (e.g. town hall meetings, online surveys) convenient? Is there anything about the timing, location, or format that could be improved?

A5. Has language been a barrier when trying to engage with these decisions or activities? In what situations was this most noticeable?

A6. Have you ever felt confused by government documents or processes because of cultural differences? Could you give an example?

Theme A3: Observation

A7. Based on your experience, do you think local government consultation processes genuinely address the needs of immigrants or residents who don't speak English as a first language?

A8. Have you seen examples that worked well, or worked poorly? (e.g. a consultation that reached a broad audience, or one that almost no one knew about)

Theme A4: Support needed to participate

A9. Thinking about the last time you either did or didn't take part in a consultation — what kind of support would have made it easier for you? (e.g. translated materials, an interpreter, evening/weekend timing, childcare, someone to explain the process first, transport)

Group B: Policy-Unaware Immigrants

Theme B1: Reasons for unfamiliarity

B1. Before this interview, had you ever heard the term "local council," or known that your area has one that makes local decisions?

B2. What do you think is the main reason you haven't come across this kind of information? (not interested, don't know where to look, language, no one told you, lost interest over time, etc.)

B3. Was there ever a period when you were more aware or engaged with local government, and it faded? What changed?

Theme B2: Hypothetical engagement

B4. If your local council were making a decision that could affect your daily life (e.g. changes to a park, public transport, or your street), would you want to know about it? Why or why not?

B5. If something were going to directly affect your street or neighborhood, do you think you'd still find out about it somehow (e.g. through neighbor community groups)? How?

B6. What kind of information or activity would have to reach you for you to actually notice it? (e.g. a flyer in your mailbox, a post in a community WeChat/Facebook group, someone from your community telling you in person)

Theme B3: Support needed to participate (RQ1)

B7. Even if you knew about a consultation, what would make it easier or harder for you to actually take part? (e.g. language, time of day, needing to travel somewhere, feeling confident enough to speak up)

B8. Is there a type of support that, if it existed, would make you much more likely to get involved — even just a little (e.g. a short survey instead of a meeting, someone from your own community explaining it first, materials in your language)?

Theme B4: Communication needs (RQ3 — community member side)

B9. What kind of message or information source would you actually trust and pay attention to, if local government wanted to reach someone like you? (a person, a platform, a type of language/tone)

B10. Is there anything about how government communicates in general (not just local council) that makes you tune out or not bother reading it?

Part 3: Trust

Did you have any experience participating in local public affairs in your home country? How does it compare to here?

Is there anything that makes you hesitant to voice opinions to the government (e.g. concerns related to visa/residency status)?

Part 4: Suggestions

1. What do you think local government staff most need to be aware of, or improve on, when communicating with communities like yours?
2. Is there anything else related to this topic that we haven't asked about, but that you'd like to add?

Appendix 2: Observation results

The following is the summaries of all the observation we have conducted, complete notes can be found in: G14_Observation_note

Observation 1- The Future Melbourne Committee: Held by the City Of Melbourne. We considered this one crucial is because this is the most straightforward example where the residents can have a direct conversation straight to the council. To our surprise, the participation rate of the committee is extremely high, where the seats are almost full. We have some quick conversations with the people joining in, and we found out that this is usually not the case. Since the one we attended has a big case where the residents here really care about, lots of people join this committee.

It is also remarkable that the order on the committee is very good, even the pro and con side would be polite to each other, and the council listen to the citizens' opinions as well.

Observation 2 - At the Arts Centre Melbourne Spire: We found that most of the people that pay attention to the notice on the board are tourists since they are on the way to some spots and they might be curious about the things on the way or someone is trying to introduce the spot. We also observed an elder trying to explain and describe the history of the building, making people interested and join the conversation as well. We notice that most of the people that pay attention to the notice are usually in pairs or groups instead of being alone.

Observation 3 - Chinese Book Club at Library at The Dock: Though the event called book club, it provided more than access to books. It helped participants meet others, communicate in their preferred language, exchange information, and reduce social isolation. There are many residents here may not have fluent English, so it is helpful if there are events where they can practice English, so they have the chance to improve. The library actually functions more like a traditional library. It provides community activities, cultural programs, practical facilities, information, and opportunities for social interaction.

Additional information that we want to mention as well is that the website the government provided is rather difficult hard for us to use; it's something worth noticing since this kind of design may decrease the interests of the public.

Appendix 3: Interview results

The following summaries the response from each interviewee, the full version of the transcripts can be found in: G14_Interview_Transcrpt

Participant 1 – P1:

P1 is an immigrant who has lived in Melbourne for around 17 years, and P1 is aware of the local council and P1 usually gets mails of information in the letterbox, which is P1's main source of information. The reason why P1 doesn't participate in much local council is because P1 doesn't feel like there's a need to oppose the policy now. Language is also a problem for P1 since P1 main language isn't English.

Participant 2 – P2:

P2 is an immigrant who has lived in Melbourne for around 10 years, and P2 is aware of the local council but doesn't have high interests towards it since P2 thinks the policies usually are not relevant to her. P2 main sources of information are social media and mail in the mailbox. P2 suggested that the time of each meeting or committee held by the council can be adjusted for more people to join.

Participant 3 – P3:

P3 is an immigrant who has lived in Melbourne for around 3 years, and P3 is aware of the local council and P3 usually gets mails of information in the letterbox. One of the problems P3 mentioned is that is hard to get information P3 needed. For example, it is hard for P3 to find local groceries since there aren't many websites that offer this kind of information. As for the local council meeting, P3 finding time is a big factor, and it also needs additional effort to understand the policy in advance. Language is also one of the barriers for P3 since P3's main language isn't English. P3 also finds the complexity of the system in Melbourne is confusing; however, P3 thinks it's adaptable. P3 also thinks that the police in different towns are not unified is a problem as well because it's hard to remember different places' policies.

Participant 4 – P4:

P4 is an immigrant who has live in Melbourne for a long time, and P4 is familiar with both councils that P4 lived in since P4 has moved out before. P4 also cares more about the policies that would affect everyday life. For example, P4 has a dog, so P4 would pay extra attention to the policy that would benefit dogs. P4 also found that there's a difference in staff's attitude in different places, hence the attitude would be a factor for P4 to consider participating or not. P4 also found it hard to find people to discuss or complain if P4 has a problem with the policy or activities.

Participant 5 – P5:

P5 is an international student who has lived in Melbourne for around 2 months, and P5 finds public policies and activities rather interesting, P5's main source of information is social media. P5 also thinks how relevant the policy or activity is to P5 to increase interest as well. P5 sometimes would check on government's website to check student visa's information such as fees and think that the website can have some improvements since the websites' description isn't clear enough. Also, P5 thinks if the government wants to have a better information transmission, it is recommended to cooperate with some of the student associate groups like student unions for target audiences like students to have an easier approach.

Participant 6 – P6:

P6 is an immigrant who has lived in Melbourne for around 12 years, and P6 only cares about the policies that related to P6's life. P6 also suggests that language is part of the problem of why people won't want to participate. P6 also thinks the local facilities here are less effective than back P6's hometown since they don't have too much authority here.

Participant 7 – P7:

P7 is an international student who has lived in Melbourne for around 7 months. P7 considered itself a civically engaged resident in both home country and Melbourne. P7 also suggested that the relevance of the policy or activity for P7 would also boost the interest for P7 to participate more. Language is one of the barriers for P7 to join relevant activity. P7 also found it hard for P7 to find the information P7 wants to know since P7 doesn't know where the information can be found.

Participant 8– P8:

P8 is an international student who has lived in Melbourne for around 10 months, and P8 doesn't have a strong interest toward public policies since P8 thinks most of them don't affect P8. Friends around P8 don't talk too much about policies or relevant topics; P8's main source of information is social media like Instagram. However, P8 would check on some events on the City of Melbourne website or check on the information pillar on the streets if P8 has the free time to do so. P8 also found that language is a difficulty as well since English isn't P8's main language. The functionality of the government's services is mentioned as well since P8 found it difficult and complicated. For example, to register an app, it might need to register another app to complete it which is frustrating to P8. P8 also suggested that the ways of information being spread should be improved. For example, P8 found it hard to know the information about trams being replaced or stopped beforehand so that P8 can make adjustments.

Appendix 4:

4.1 – Coding progress from each team member (Retrieve)

Yen-Chu OU YANG:

notice what's happened nearby his community

Another example concerned planning rules for building heights. The council may change an area's future use—for example, allowing more commercial activity or retaining more residential use—and adjust the permitted heights of new buildings.

The information identifies the relevant streets or areas and uses different colours on a map to show the permitted building heights. If you later renovate or build a house, you have to follow those rules. I remember finding this type of material in my mailbox.

Q7. What happens if an individual wants to build or renovate a house? understand the process of application

A: The owner has to submit an application and the proposed design to the council. The council explains the restrictions that apply in that area and reviews the application. Work can begin only after approval is granted.

Part 2: Policy-Aware Immigrant

Theme A1: Awareness and Information Channels

A1. Do you actively follow council policies, meetings or consultation activities?

A: Not very much. I might look at them occasionally, but I do not actively follow them.

A2. Have the channels you use to get this kind of information changed over time?

A: Physical mail has remained the main channel for this kind of public-policy information. Sometimes I also learn something by talking with neighbours.

physical mails and neighbor are the main channal

Theme A2: Participation Experience

A3. Have you attended a council information session, public hearing or survey intended to collect residents' views?

A: No, I have not taken part in those activities.

A4. Why have you not participated? only aware of the topic that will affected him.

A: The main reason is that the issues have usually felt quite distant from me. Also, the policies and proposals I have encountered so far have generally seemed acceptable.

I have not felt that I needed to oppose them or take any particular action, so I have generally accepted them.

A5. Has language been a barrier when trying to engage with these decisions or activities?

A: Yes. Language was especially a factor when I first arrived, and it can still be a factor now.

Other members of my family are generally okay with English, but they have their own work and do not normally participate in these matters either.

language barrier > cultural difference

Part 2: Policy-aware vs. Policy Unaware

No motivation for her to engage in council events.

Theme B1: Reasons for unfamiliarity

B1. Before this interview, have you ever heard of the term "local council," or knew your area has one that makes local decisions?

A: I know the local council, but I've never really met any of them. But I do know that Keysborough is part of the greater Dandenong Council.

B2. What do you think is the main reason you haven't come across this kind of information?

(not interested, don't know where to look, language, no one told you, lost interest over time, etc.)

A: I just don't feel there's a need to look at this information.

B3. Was there a time period when you were specifically aware of or engaged with local government? What changed?

A: Probably not I don't think so.

Theme B2: Hypothetical engagement*

B4. If your local council was making a decision that could affect your daily life (e.g. changes to a park, public transport, or your street), would you want to know about it? Why or why not?

A: Yeah, I think so. I feel like it's affecting Me in my personal life. Yeah, I would like to know more about it.

B5. If something affects your street or neighborhood in the future, do you think you notice that beforehand? (e.g. through neighbors, community groups)? How?

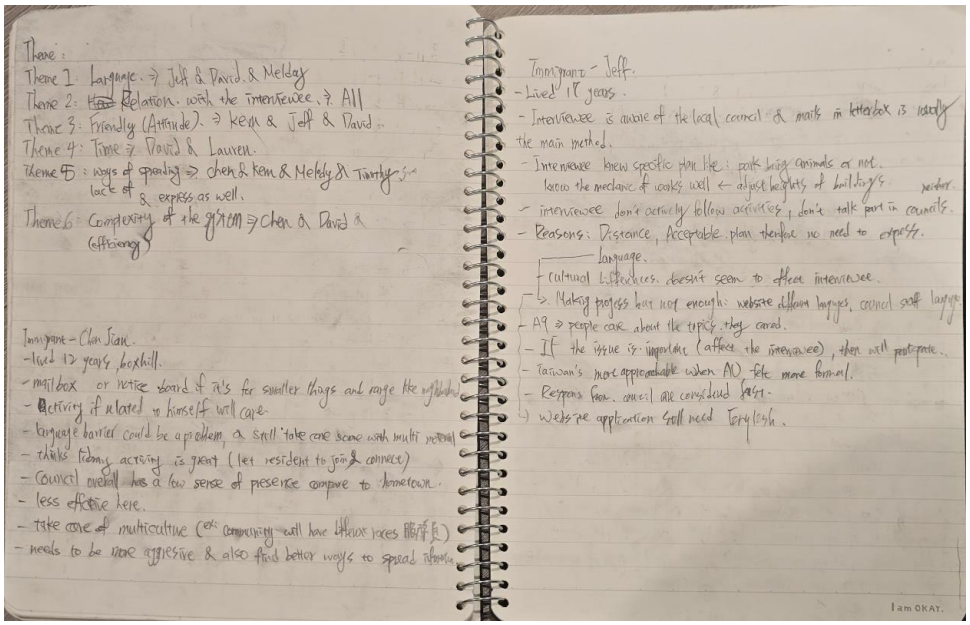
A: I think once it started to influence my life then I will notice that. But otherwise, I don't think I will actively be looking for any news.

B6. Do you think there are better approaches for you to get information of the policies or activities easier? (e.g. a flyer in your mailbox, a post in a community WeChat/Facebook group, someone from your community telling you in person)

A: I think a flyer in my mailbox will probably Be the most effective method Just because I then can have a look in the time that's I'm free.

She will probably reach out to council only when the policy or events that will affect her life.

Yu-Hao LU:



Jia-Ying Lee:

Another example concerned planning rules for building heights. The council may change an area's future use—for example, allowing more commercial activity or retaining more residential use—and adjust the permitted heights of new buildings.

The information identifies the relevant streets or areas and uses different colours on a map to show the permitted building heights. If you later renovate or build a house, you have to follow those rules. I remember finding this type of material in my mailbox.

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A: Yes. Language was especially a factor when I first arrived, and it can still be a factor now.

Other members of my family are generally okay with English, but they have their own work and do not normally participate in these matters either.

Q22: When you first arrived, or when you had a real problem, did you ever go directly to the Council or a local support/community organization to ask for help in person?

A: (Clarifying question about "in person") No, I haven't done that — I've never gone to a citizen service center in person.

Q23: Comparing your experience of "community support" here to Taiwan, what do you think Australia's government could do better in this area, if anything?

A: There are pros and cons — it's a hard question.

The cons:

- **Efficiency** — Taiwan's efficiency is higher; here, sending a letter or asking a question might take a long time to get a response.

The pros:

- Makes you feel a high sense of "emotional value" — they tell you clearly what support is available and how to access it.
- Every letter lists what kind of help is available and where to go.
- Provides support tailored to different backgrounds — e.g., as someone from Taiwan/Chinese background, there are Chinese community groups/clubs he can join.
- Population density factor: even though efficiency is lower, fewer people use the services, so facilities (like the community swimming pool, local supermarkets) feel less crowded and are well-maintained.

Q24: Comparing your past experience in Taiwan and current experience in Australia, was there anything that surprised you (positively or negatively) — e.g., you mentioned the time/efficiency issue?

A: That covers it well. Also public hospitals — I went once, and it was the same as before: low efficiency, long wait times, but also not many people there, and few staff. Not like Taiwanese hospitals, which are crowded every day with people rushing around. So the two systems are quite different — solving problems in each place requires different approaches, because if you want efficiency, you may need to pay more money for it.

Q25: From your answers, it sounds like you feel Australian government is quite transparent about providing residents with info — like what facilities or communities exist in an area. Does this increase your sense of belonging, or make you feel like part of Australia when you have a problem?

A: Yes, I think so. I feel this aspect is valued/respected. Even though actually getting the information can still be a bit difficult, you can see that City Council or other government

Xintong FU:

Theme A2: Participation Experience

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A4. Why have you not participated?

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Other members of my family are generally okay with English, but they have their own work and do not normally participate in these matters either.

A6. Have cultural differences made government policies or processes difficult to understand?

A: Not particularly. Cultural differences have not been a major source of confusion for me.

Theme A3: Observation of Consultation and Inclusion

A7. Do local-government consultation processes adequately consider immigrants and residents whose first language is not English?

A: Personally, I do not think they have always considered this group enough, but I think councils are making an effort.

itt 2天
No formal consultation experrience

itt 2天
low personal relevance

itt 2天
satisfaction reduces motivation to participate

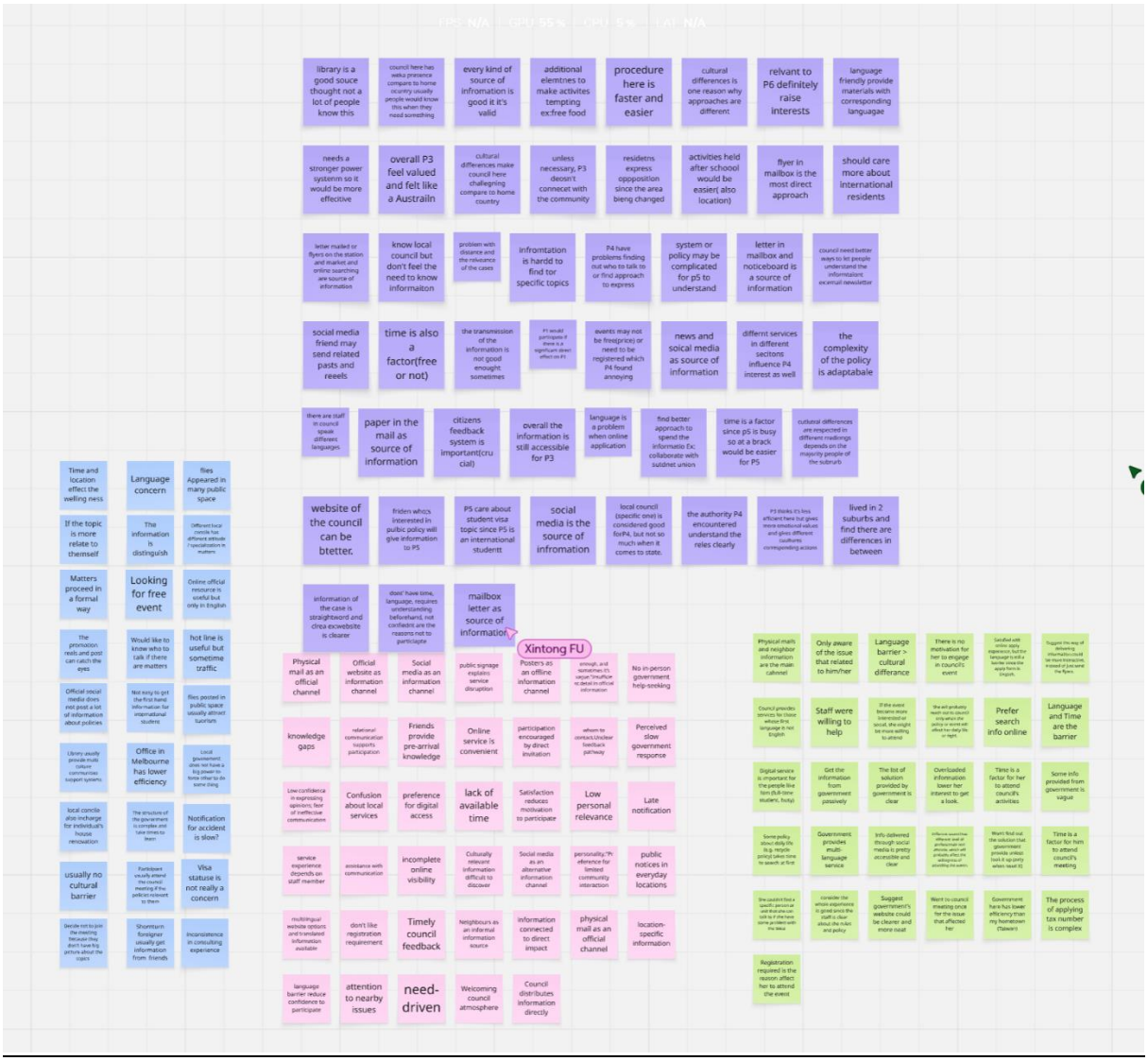
itt 2天
Participation associated with opposition; acceptance leads to non-participation

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continuing language barrier reduced confidence to participate

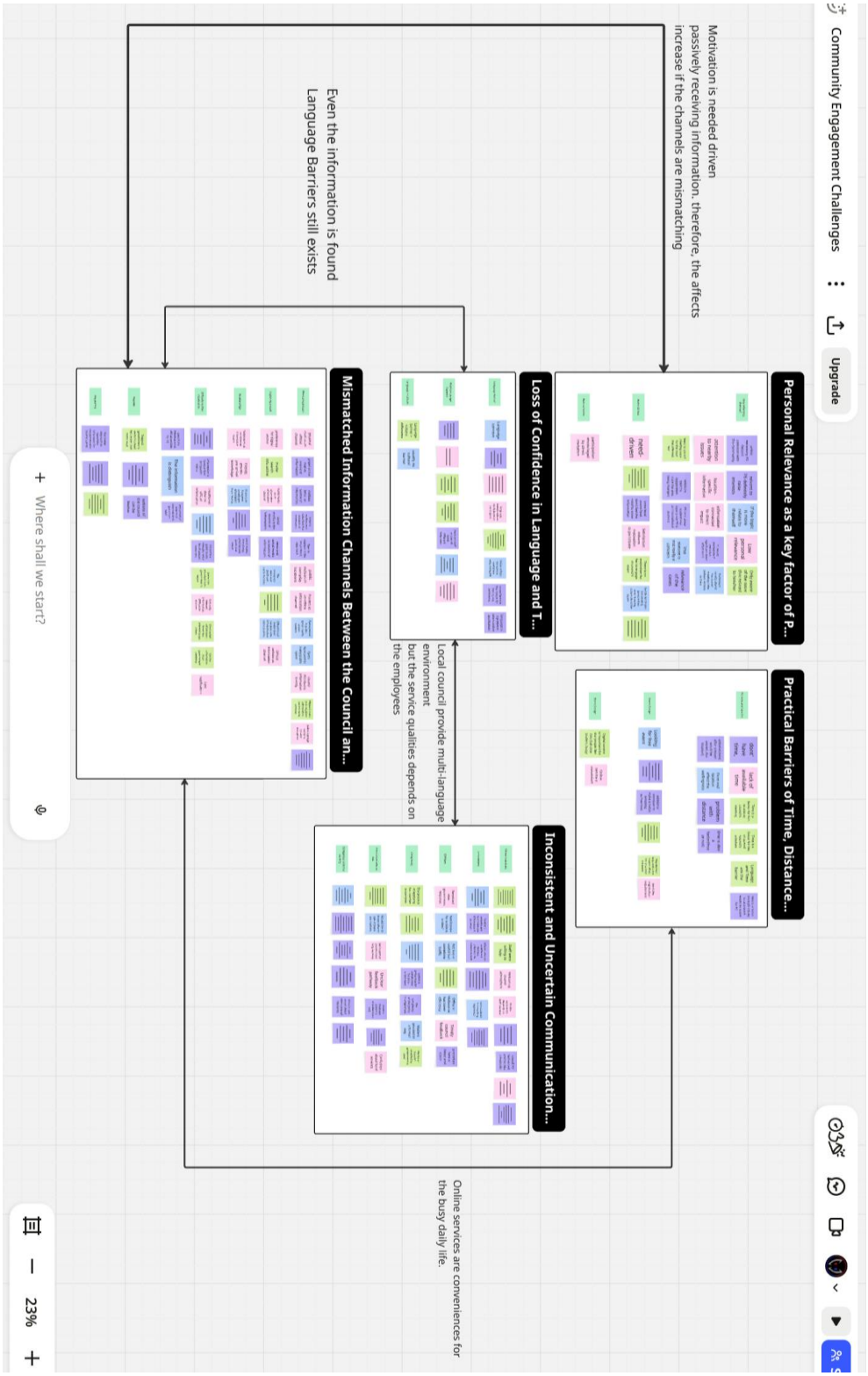
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cultural differences not experienced as a barrier

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4.2 – Codes

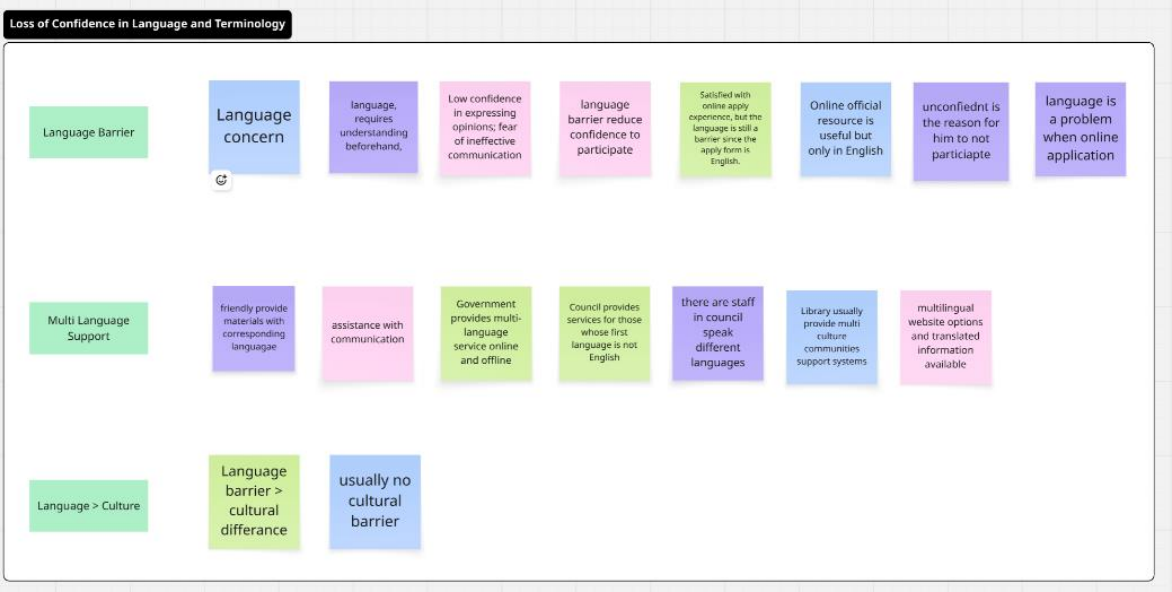


4.3 – Themes and connections

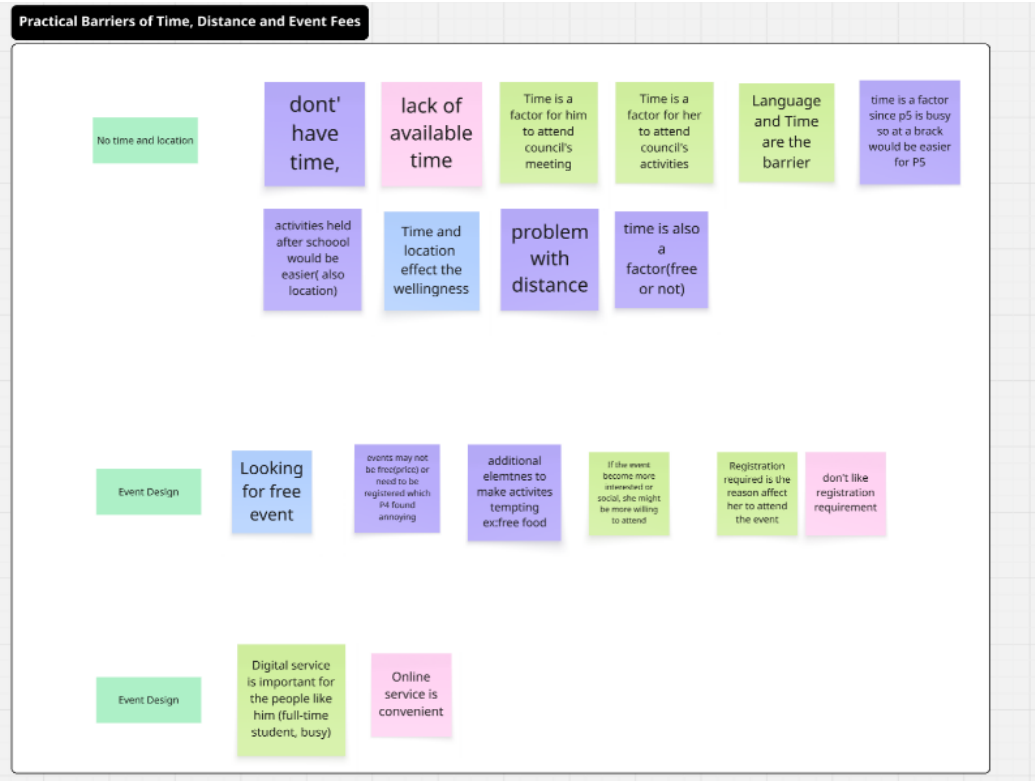


Appendix 5: Affinity diagram

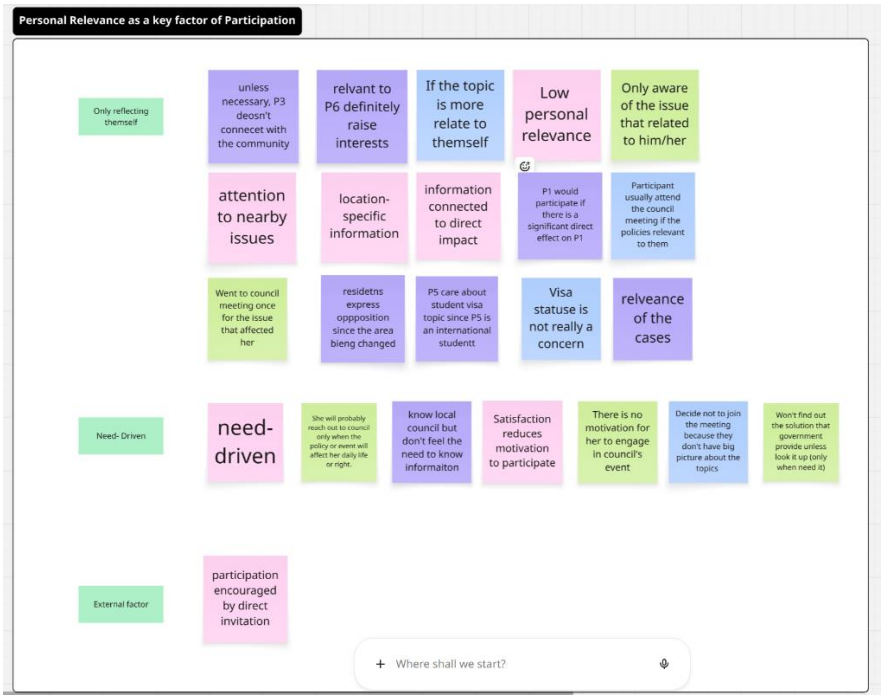
5.1 - Theme 1: Loss of Confidence in Language and Terminology



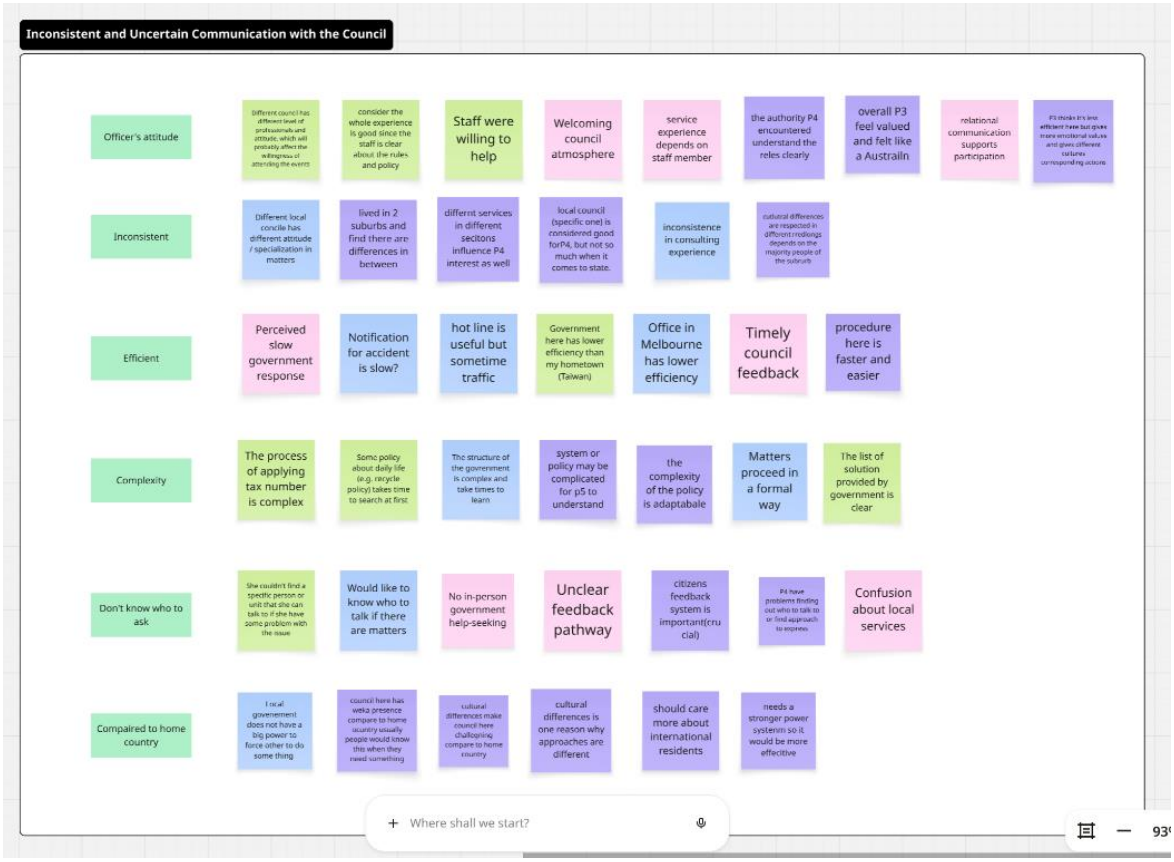
5.2 - Theme 2: Practical Barriers of Time, Distance and Event Fees



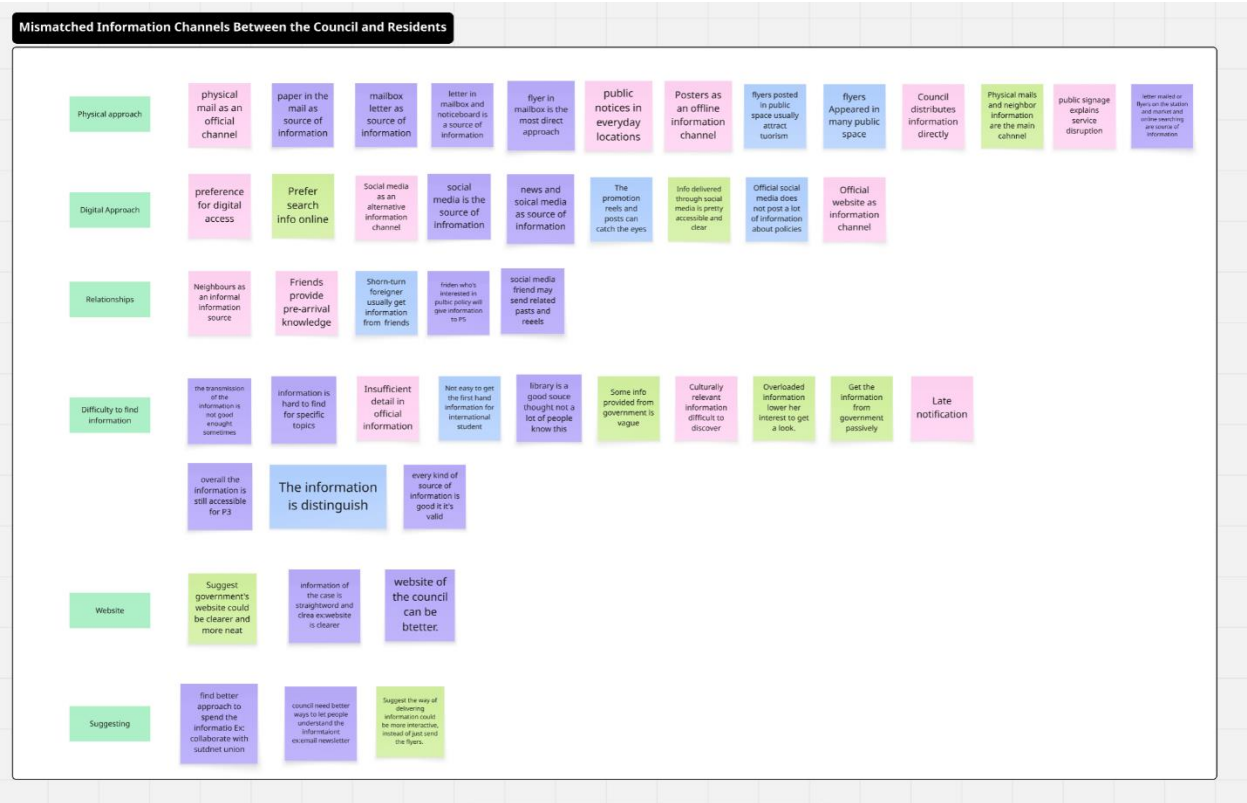
5.3 - Theme 3: Personal Relevance as a key factor of Participation



5.4 - Theme 4: Inconsistent and Uncertain Communication with the Council



5.5 - Theme 5: Mismatched Information Channels Between the Council and Residents



Appendix 6: Meeting Records

Date/Time	11/08/2026 14:00-15:00
Location	ERC library Project Room 211
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Confirm the topic decision • Search the information about council • Plan to attend the meeting in council (Town Hall)

Date/Time	18/08/2026 14:00-15:00
Location	Giblin library Project Room 10
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Discuss the method of investigation and the target group ○ Method: Interview and observation ○ Target Audience: Internation student

Date/Time	25/08/2026 14:00-15:00
Location	Baillieu library Project Room 6
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Draft interview question • Discuss the observation results. • Start to find interviewees

Date/Time	01/09/2026 14:00-15:00
Location	ERC library Project Room 212
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Find more events on Melbourne's library website • Plan to attend the conversation session at Kathleen Syme Library and Community Centre. • Plan to attend Chinese Book Club at The Dock Library to do an observation. • Discuss the findings of past interviews.

Date/Time	08/09/2026 14:00-15:00

Location	Melbourne Connect
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Discuss the observation result of Chinese Book Club.

Date/Time	15/09/2026 15:00-16:00
Location	FBE Library
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Discuss the findings of past interviews. • Brainstorming the potential solution addressing the field work we have taken.

Date/Time	22/09/2026 15:00-16:00
Location	Melbourne Connect
Attendee	All group members
Note	• Discuss the idea of prototype. • Check the document.